and another where the system determines it:

```
POST <index_alias>/_rollover/<target_index_name>
```

Specifying a target index name, as given in the second option, lets the rollover API create the index with the given parameter as the target index name. However, the first option, where we don't provide an index name, has a special convention: `<index_name>-00000N`. The number (after the dash) is always six digits with padded zeros. If our index follows this format, rolling over creates a new index with the same prefix, but the suffix is automatically incremented to the next number: `<index_name>-00000N +1`. The increment starts from wherever the original index number is: for example, `my_cars-000034` is incremented to `my_cars-000035`.

You may wonder when you would want to roll over an index. That is up to you. When you think the index is clogged, or you need to (re)move older data, you can invoke a rollover. However, first ask yourself:

- Can you we automatically roll over the index when the shard's size has crossed a certain threshold?
- Can you instantiate a new index for everyday logs?

Although we have seen the rollover mechanism in this section, we can satisfy these questions using the relatively new *index lifecycle management* (ILM) feature, which is discussed at length in the next section.

6.9 Index lifecycle management (ILM)

Indexes are expected to grow in size as data pours in over time. Sometimes an index is written too frequently, and the underlying shards run out of memory; other times, most of the shards are sparsely filled. Wouldn't it be ideal to automatically roll over the index in the former case and shrink it in the latter?

NOTE Index lifecycle management (ILM) is an advanced topic, and you may not need it when starting with Elasticsearch. If that's the case, you can skip this section and return to it when you need to learn how Elasticsearch deals with time-series data and how to act on indexes by rolling them over, freezing or deleting them based on certain conditions "automagically" (well, based on defined policies), and more.

We also need to consider time-series data. Take an example of logs written to a file daily. These logs are then exported to indexes suffixed with a period, like `my-app-2021-10-24.log`. When a day is rolled off to the next day, the respective index should be rolled over, too: for example, `my-app-2021-10-24.log` to `my-app-2021-10-25.log` (the date is incremented by day), as figure 6.10 shows.

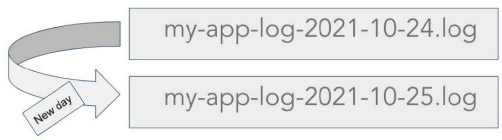


Figure 6.10 Rolling over to a new index when the new day dawns